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ALL THE BEST
(Clockwise from left) An old diesel-run double-decker bus in Mumbai; a new battery-operated AC double-decker

MUMBAI'S DOUBLE-DECKERS

INTO THE SUNSET

wish to be named. Around 1997-98, BEST had around 900 double-deckers in service, but the numbers gradually dwindled as old vehicles went out of service and no fresh additions were made. "The double-deckers had steeper operational costs due to higher fuel consumption and required two conductors, including one for the upper deck," says Sunil Ganacharya, a former member of the BEST committee, adding that the growth in vehicular traffic also affected the ability to manoeuvre these buses on Mumbai's busy roads.

The double-deckers in their new e-avatar promise to address a lot of these issues. "These AC buses will provide a comfortable and safe travel experience," says Sunil Vaidya, senior administrative officer, PRO department, BEST. "They will have two entry and exit points (the old buses had just one at the rear), CCTVs and charging points." These battery-operated buses will not only reduce BEST's carbon footprint, but will also be more cost-effective compared to the diesel-guzzling double-deckers. "BEST plans to deploy the next lot of 10 buses," adds Vaidya, "in the city's northern suburbs. The minimum fare will be Rs 6, as against Rs 5 for normal buses."

The new buses are being inducted on a 'wet lease' basis from private operators, who will control part of the operations like maintenance and providing drivers. BEST has also decided to purchase new open deck buses for the 'Mumbai Darshan' tourist circuit to replace the Nilambari buses that are being scrapped. For the time being, five AC double-deckers will be deployed on these routes.

But bus and public transport enthusiasts lament that despite the air-conditioned comfort that they promise, the new buses lack the thrill and grace of the old buses. "The old double-deckers were on the lines of the London buses...very spacious and attractive," says Mumbai-based historian Deepak Rao. "The buses had a wide entrance at the rear, allowing around four to five people to board them at a time. The youngsters would immediately rush to the upper deck, which offered a panoramic view of the city." Ganacharya, meanwhile, feels BEST should have inducted the old, non-AC double-deckers to continue with this tradition. Or, at least, he says, the BMC should provide grants to BEST to maintain some of these old buses for the sake of nostalgia. ■